

Symbian Silverlight

Microsoft to launch Silverlight for the Symbian platform soon

Goodbye Firefox 3.0

As Mozilla issues its last update, check out our hunt for the world's fastest browser on Thinkdigit.com (<http://bit.ly/aXnGod>)

Speaker test

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The most action packed movie, the most exciting of games, the highest quality audio can only truly be enjoyed on an equally good set of speakers. Imagine watching Transformers on a pair of cheap headphones without the stomach churning bass or the screaming sounds of missiles flying from one corner of the room to another. Desktop speakers aren't there to simply amplify the sound you would hear on your laptop speakers—they manage to get you a whole lot closer to the real thing and that's what huge TVs and projectors are meant to do, right?

It's time now for our yearly roundup of speakers. We're hoping that a lot has changed and things are moving upwards again. Last we checked, the desktop speaker market was going south. The home theater market on the other hand seems to be more happening with many more models coming up. We called in models from all of the brands we could find. We got well over 50 speakers in all ranging across all categories.

As always, we split up the

speakers into categories, each pertaining to a particular kind of user and needs. The three primary categories we fixed on were 2.0 speakers, 2.1 speakers and surround speakers (4.1 and 5.1 speakers).

For those who find themselves new to these terms, 2.0 speakers are those without the subwoofer and just the two primary speakers. The 2.1 category includes speakers with an additional woofer which is responsible for the low frequencies of the sound spectrum. These two categories are for pure music enthusiasts who will, every now and then use the speakers while watching movies. The surround sound speaker category is meant to give solutions for movie buffs and gaming enthusiasts. The need for surround sound is essential to them. We also received a few iPod docks and portable speakers that would be handy for those travelling very often. You'll find them all over this test.

This was going to be an exciting test also because of some new brands that made an appearance, most notably

being Sony which is by now well known in the consumer electronics market. A brand by the name of F&D also made an entry with lots of interesting products of all shapes and sizes. Our regular participants – Creative, Altec Lansing, Artis and Zebronics were present with some new models as well. Maybe, things weren't looking too bad after all.



2.0 speakers

A group of 12 speakers make up the list of contenders for the 2.0 speakers category. There were speakers starting from as little as Rs. 225 going right up through the roof to Rs. 15,000.

Features, design and build quality

When we think of build quality in the history of desktop

speakers that have come to the Test Centre, one of the first products that comes to mind is the Audioengine A2. This time around, it's still the best built product in this category. We've tested them in the past and we still love them. Everything about the product speaks of attention to detail and quality. The driver cones are made of kevlar, the connectors at the back and the cable quality are also top notch. The dial feels like something that would go into a space shuttle console.

Creative isn't only about the Inspire lineup. Sure, they have an edge over some of the smaller vendors, but their cheaper models aren't particularly well built.

Their Gigaworks lineup on the other hand sets things straight. The Gigaworks HD50 model means business. Cable quality for example, is fantastic. The body quality is comparable to the Audioengine A2. The front covers come off revealing a very clean and well crafted frame and drivers. The volume control has a good feel to it and for those who like a little bling, it

ALTEC LANSING ORBIT USB IML237

Those travelling and computing on a laptop might want to look at the Altec Lansing Orbit USB IML237. Technically, it's only a single full-range driver that is powered by USB. It's got an in-built sound card, so you don't really need to use a 3.5mm jack.

Coming to the power, it's loud enough if you're the only one sitting in front of it. Audio quality is decent and the tone is pretty normal. There is no bass-producing mechanism hidden in it. The sound quality in general is decent, but it can be pretty annoying listening to music from one side. The optimum position would be exactly in front of you but then you'd have to do something silly like keep your laptop to one side.

The design is very attractive, with a clean golden look, like those found on some Subaru Impreza cars. There's a small foldable stand which lets the speaker face you and the quality of plastic used is good. The IML237 is a handy product that comes with a carry pouch and strap. Our only problem is that it doesn't come with a 3.5mm jack to connect other devices to it, and its price of Rs. 2,790, makes it ridiculously expensive and hard to recommend.

